Heidel – Chapter IV: Old Testament Parallels (the Flood)

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CHAPTER IV

THE STORY OF THE FLOOD

The most remarkable parallels between the Old Testament and the Gilgamesh Epic—in fact, the most remarkable parallels between the Old Testament and the entire corpus of cuneiform inscriptions from Mesopotamia—are found in the deluge accounts of the Babylonians and Assyrians, on the one hand, and the Hebrews, on the other. With the study of this material we therefore enter a field which, a priori, should prove most fruitful in our examination of the genetic relationship between the Mesopotamian records and our Old Testament literature. Here, if anywhere, we should expect to find evidence enabling us to decide the question whether any part of the Old Testament has been derived from Babylonian sources. It is therefore with special interest that we shall make the following inquiry.

The Authors of the Flood

The Book of Genesis, consonant with Hebrew monotheism, attributes the sending of the deluge to the one and only true God recognized in the Old Testament, while the cuneiform tablets represent a multitude of divinities as engaged in bringing about this fearful catastrophe. In the Sumerian inscription from Nippur it is stated that the deluge was decreed by the assembly of the gods. But their decision, even though evidently approved by all, at least formally, did not receive the wholehearted support of all the divinities of the pantheon; for Nintu, the goddess of birth, deplored the approaching destruction of the human family and wailed like a woman in travail, while Enki, the god of wisdom and the benefactor of humanity, took counsel in his own heart to save at least his favorite, Ziusudra, whom he subsequently informed of the purpose of the gods and to whom he also imparted a plan of escaping the impending fate of mankind. According to the eleventh tablet of the Gilgamesh Epic, the flood was decreed by “the great gods.” There was Anu, their father; warlike Enlil, their counselor; Ninurta, their representative; Ennugi, their vizier; and Ea, the Enki of the Sumerians (cf. lines 14-19). Moreover, we learn that Ishtar, the goddess of propagation, also had an important voice in the council of the gods, for, after the storm had broken loose in all its fury, she lamented: “In truth, the olden time has turned to clay, because I commanded evil in the assembly of the gods! How could I command (such) evil in the assembly of the gods! (How) could I command war to destroy my people!” (lines 118-21). However, after Utnapishtim’s sacrifice on the mountaintop, both Ishtar and Ea stigmatized Enlil as the real author of this unwarranted catastrophe (cf. lines 156-85). Here, as well as in the Sumerian version, it was doubtless Enlil who was principally responsible for the deluge. He had received the supreme power and function of Anu, the highest god of the early Babylonian pantheon, and now he probably imposed his will upon the other gods, who did not dare to oppose him seriously and who therefore more or less acquiesced in his decision.^[618]

The Reason for the Flood

As the cause for the cataclysm, the Old Testament emphasizes the moral depravity of the human race. Man could have averted this unparalleled destruction of life if he had conformed his ways to the will of his Maker, but instead of that he followed his own inclinations. The whole bent of the thoughts of his heart was never anything but evil. The earth was corrupt before God and was filled with violence because of man, for all flesh had corrupted its way upon the earth (Gen. 6:1-13).

In the Gilgamesh Epic the reason for the deluge is not nearly so apparent as it is in the Book of Genesis. The opening lines of the flood story contained in the epic state simply that the heart of the great gods prompted them to bring a deluge (Tablet XI:14). From this passage one might get the impression that the flood was due to divine caprice. But according to Ea's speech toward the close of the account, where he reprimands Enlil for this thoughtless and unjustifiable destruction, the flood was sent because of the sin of man. Unfortunately, this does not give us any clue as to the nature of man's offense.

An answer to this question is given in the fragmentary Atraḫasis Epic. Starting out much like Genesis, chapter 6, the epic states that, when the people had multiplied and, apparently, had become prosperous, they became so noisy as to deprive Enlil of his sleep.^[619] In an attempt to quiet them, Enlil sent plague after plague. But, in the final analysis, it was all of no avail; mankind became more numerous (and evidently more noisy) than before. In utter exasperation, Enlil at last sent the flood to destroy them all and to put an end to their unbearable noise. The case is analogous, in a sense, to Apsû's struggle against the younger gods, whose incessant noise disturbed his slothful rest and finally prompted him to decree their annihilation,^[620] and to a passage in the Irra Epic, where Anu says to Irra, concerning the seven gods whom Anu had placed at Irra's disposal: "When the tumult of the people of the earth has become (too) painful for thee, and thy heart moves thee to set the snare, to kill the black-headed (people), to lay low the beast of the plain, (then) let these be thy raging weapons and let them go at thy sides."^[621]

In the Book of Genesis the deluge is a righteous retribution for the sins of the ungodly, while pious Noah and his family are spared, with the full knowledge and the express purpose of Him who sent the flood. The biblical story thus exemplifies the pronouncement of the prophet Ezekiel: "The soul that sinneth shall die. The son shall not bear the iniquity of the father, neither shall the father bear the iniquity of the son; the righteousness of the righteous shall be upon him, and the wickedness of the wicked shall be upon him" (18:20 [cf. Deut. 24:16; II Kings 14:6]). But in the cuneiform inscriptions the destruction is intended for all alike, for the just as well as for the unjust, without any exception whatsoever. This is particularly clear from the words with which Ea reproached Enlil: "On the sinner lay his sin; on the transgressor lay his transgression!" (Tablet XI:180). This line from the epic shows unmistakably that not all were sinners. Yet had it not been

for Ea's intervention, Enlil, in his rashness, would have destroyed all human and animal life without discrimination and thus would have defeated the very purpose for which, according to the Babylonian creation stories, mankind and the animals had been created, viz., to supply the wants of the gods. Whether Enlil, like Jupiter in Ovid's Metamorphoses (i. 250 ff.), had planned a new creation of men after the deluge is not indicated in any of the Babylonian flood stories at our disposal. But, whatever may be said about the wisdom of Enlil's scheme, there was little justice in it.

The Hero of the Flood

The name of the deluge hero varies with the different recensions. The Sumerian account calls him Ziusudra, which means something like "he who laid hold on life of distant days," the reference being to the immortality which after the flood was bestowed upon the hero. In the Gilgamesh Epic he bears the name Utnapishtim. This is obviously a free rendering of the Sumerian Ziusudra and is today commonly translated with "he saw life," i.e., he found or obtained everlasting life.^[622] Here again the name is, of course, symbolical of the role played by the deluge hero. In another version the hero is referred to by the name of Atraḫasis, meaning "the exceedingly wise." In the excerpts from Berossus he is called Xisuthros, Sisuthros, Sisithros, and Seisithros, all of which probably go back to an original Zisuthros, corresponding to the Sumerian Ziusudra. In the Bible his name appears as Noah, meaning "rest." The Book of Genesis makes no attempt to establish a relation between the name and the experiences of the central human figure in the account of the flood.

Utnapishtim was the son of Ubara-Tutu, the Otiartes, or, rather, Opartes of Berossus. According to Berossus, the deluge hero was the tenth prediluvian king in Babylonia. Also in the Sumerian inscription he is referred to as king; there he occupies also a priestly office, viz., that of the administrator of the temple provisions of a certain god. In the Gilgamesh Epic, Utnapishtim is not vested with any royal power or intrusted with any priestly office; from it we learn simply that he was a citizen of Shurippak (Tablet XI:23) and a man of considerable wealth (XI:70 ff.). Noah was the son of Lamech and the tenth prediluvian patriarch (Genesis, chap. 5).

Utnapishtim dwelt in the city of Shurippak (or Shuruppak), which was one of the oldest cities in southern Babylonia and which today is represented by the mounds of Fâra, about eighteen miles northwest of Uruk. Shuruppak is listed also among the five antediluvian cities enumerated in the Sumerian Nippur version. In the Hebrew account no city at all is mentioned in connection with the hero of the flood.

As indicated before, Noah escaped destruction because of his godliness. He was a righteous and faultless man among his contemporaries; like Enoch, he walked with God (Gen. 6:9) and thus was in the most intimate relation with God. This made the performance of the will of God self-evident. When, therefore, he was ordered to build the ark, he showed no signs of doubt or

unwillingness but obeyed and carried out the command. The piety of the deluge hero is emphasized also in the Sumerian account; there he is called the administrator of the temple provisions, and there it is stated that he prostrated himself in reverence and humility and that he daily and perseveringly stood in attendance at the shrine. After the flood he again prostrated himself in adoration and offered an abundant sacrifice. This characteristic can be inferred also from the Gilgamesh Epic; for upon Ea's announcement of the impending catastrophe he showed reverence to his divine overlord, he hearkened to the voice of his god, and carried out his instructions; after the flood he offered up a sacrifice to placate the gods. Finally, Berossus states that Xisuthros "obeyed" the instructions of his god and that he was translated to the society of the gods because of his piety.

The Announcement of the Flood

The manner in which the impending cataclysm was announced to the deluge hero in the Babylonian stories differs widely from the way in which it was revealed to the Old Testament Noah. According to the Sumerian version, Ziusudra had an extraordinary dream, "such as had not been (before)." Apparently, in view of its singular character, he conjured by the name of heaven and earth either to determine the meaning of the dream or to receive divine assurance that his interpretation of it was correct. Thereupon he heard a voice which bade him take his stand beside a wall and then told him that by the decree of the assembly of the gods a flood would be sent to destroy mankind. The remainder of the communication, which in all probability dealt with the construction of the boat, is unfortunately broken away. In the Gilgamesh Epic, Ea begins his disclosure of the things to come by addressing himself to a reed hut, probably the dwelling of the deluge hero; but then, turning to Utnapishtim, he tells him to tear down his house and build a ship according to certain specifications, to abandon his possessions, and to save his life and to take into the ship the seed of all living creatures (Tablet XI:19-31). This warning took place while Utnapishtim lay asleep in the reed hut, for, when Ea was taken to account by Enlil for having divulged the secret of the gods, he tried to justify his course of action by asserting that it really was not he who had revealed the divine resolution but that he had shown a dream to Utnapishtim and that from this dream "the exceedingly wise" had guessed the plan of the great gods (Tablet XI:170-87). Also Berossus states that Kronos, i.e., Ea, appeared to the deluge hero in a dream and warned him of the impending doom. The Atraḫasis Epic (Fragments II and III) exhibits certain features both of the Sumerian version and of the flood account embodied in the Gilgamesh Epic. Utnapishtim was not told expressly, in the Gilgamesh Epic, that a deluge would be sent in which all mankind was to perish, but he was told enough so that he could draw the necessary conclusions. This revelation was made not only without the knowledge of Enlil, the real author of the flood, but it was also quite contrary to his plan, according to which "no man was to live through the destruction" (Tablet XI:173).^[623]

In Genesis, on the other hand, Noah apparently received a direct communication; there is no indication that the will of God was conveyed to him through the medium of a dream. Furthermore, the disclosure was made by the Lord himself, and was therefore in full accord with his purpose. The God who caused the flood also saved his faithful servant by informing him of the approaching catastrophe and by ordering the building of an ark. However, all available accounts agree that the impending peril was divinely announced to the hero of the deluge.

The Period of Grace

According to Gen. 6:3, man was granted a period of grace extending over one hundred and twenty years, during which he had an opportunity to amend his sinful ways and to avert the threatened destruction (cf. I Pet. 3:20).^[624] There is no mention in the biblical text that the intended punishment was announced to Noah's contemporaries. But that this was done may be taken for granted; for, had it not been disclosed to mankind, there would have been little meaning in giving them a period of grace, particularly since they were apparently permitted to go unpunished during all this time. And since Noah was the only person who had found favor in the sight of God, it is an obvious conclusion that he was intrusted with the task of communicating the decision of God to his fellow-men (cf. II Pet. 2:5).^[625]

In the Gilgamesh Epic there was no thought of granting mankind an opportunity to repent. There the planned destruction of the human race was a zealously guarded secret of the gods. It was such an inviolable secret that even as great a divinity as Ea did not dare to communicate it directly to his favorite, Utnapishtim, but felt compelled to resort to a subterfuge, by warning the latter in a dream from which he could guess the contents of the gods' decree. And when Utnapishtim, in his dream, inquired of his divine overlord what he should answer his fellow-citizens when asked about the purpose of the building and provisioning of the boat, Ea instructed him to deceive them, lest they should learn the truth and likewise escape. Utnapishtim was to tell them in effect: "I have learned that Enlil hates me and that I may no longer dwell in your city. I will therefore go and live with Ea, my lord. Then Enlil will turn to you with his grace and favor and pour an abundant blessing upon you, which will begin with a wheat-rain on a stormy evening" (Tablet XI:32-47). Thus, as L. W. King^[626] has put it, Utnapishtim is "ordered to allay any misgivings that his fellow-citizens may feel by assuring them beforehand that the signs of the deluge are marks of coming prosperity, and not of destruction." Virtually the same deception is recorded in the extract from Berossus, where we read: "If he [i.e., Xisuthros] should be asked whither he was sailing he should say: 'To the gods, in order to pray that it may be well with mankind!' " That the gods (at least Enlil) never intended to give mankind another chance becomes even more apparent from the quarrel which ensued among the gods after the flood. When Enlil found out that a number of people had survived the flood, he was filled with anger, for it had been his determined purpose that all should perish and that no one should live! There is no indication that other means of correcting mankind had been tried before but without success. On the contrary, to judge from the way in which Ea remonstrated with Enlil for not

having resorted to less drastic measures, such as sending wild beasts, or a famine, or a pestilence among mankind to diminish their numbers, and from the fact that Enlil had nothing to say in reply to Ea's censure, it would seem that this was the first attempt on the part of the gods to curb the wickedness of man; for otherwise Enlil could have pointed out that other means had been employed before but that all had failed and that his action, consequently, was not as thoughtless as maintained by Ea (Tablet XI:170-96).

According to the Atraḫasis Epic, man was granted several periods of grace before Enlil determined to destroy the human race by means of a flood. There the decision to cause a deluge was preceded by a number of severe plagues which Enlil sent at different intervals for the purpose of inducing humanity to refrain from making so much noise. He first sent a dire famine, which lasted about six years and assumed such dimensions that parents ate their own children and that one house, or family, devoured the other. Since the people reverted to their former ways after the plague was over and after they had recovered from its effects, Enlil sent another famine, accompanied by a failure of childbirth, to diminish the numbers of the human race. At this juncture the wise man Atraḫasis interceded with Ea and in some indeterminable way effected relief. But soon the noise of mankind was as great as before, so that Enlil called a council of the gods in which it was resolved to send a pestilence among men in order to put an end to their unbearable noise. Once more Atraḫasis pleaded with Ea on behalf of groaning mankind and apparently was again successful in his effort to bring about a removal of the plague. When also this punishment failed to effect a lasting change, Enlil afflicted them with another famine attended by a cessation of births. However, despite all these visitations, the human family had not learned their lesson; for when the plague had been removed, and they were able to breathe freely again, they became as noisy and hilarious as before. Seeing that all his attempts at correcting the ways of mankind had failed, Enlil resolved to destroy the whole human race by sending a flood. And once the complete annihilation of man was decided upon, there was no more grace; for also according to this version, Enlil tried to keep the coming of the deluge a secret of the gods, as we can see from Fragment II, in order that no human soul might escape destruction.

The Ark

Another interesting point of comparison is the ark which the hero of the flood constructed. Like the hero himself, the ark is known by a number of different terms in the various flood stories. The Sumerian recension designates it as a magurgur, which means "a very great ship," "a giant boat."^[627] This word occurs also in the Semitic Babylonian deluge fragment from Nippur, where it corresponds to the Semitic phrase elippu rabîtu, used two lines previously in that text and signifying "a great ship or boat."

The Gilgamesh Epic calls this craft by the general term elippu, “vessel,” “ship,” “boat.” Once it also uses êkallu (Tablet XI:95), a word which, derived from the Sumerian language, literally means “a great house” and occurs in reference to palaces and temples. This term is employed as a poetic designation for the ark, giving “an indication of its large size, with its many stories and compartments.”^[628] In the passage under discussion I have translated it somewhat freely with “the mighty structure.”^[629] Berossus refers to the deluge boat as σκάφος, πλοῖον, and ναῦς, all three of which mean “ship,” or “boat.”

The Old Testament word for the ark is tēbâ. Outside of the biblical flood story, this term occurs only in Exod. 2:3/5, where it is applied to the reed vessel in which the infant Moses was saved. The Hebrew tēbâ is hardly related, as has been suggested, to the Babylonian ṭebîtu, denoting a deep-drawing freight ship (for in that case we should expect טֵבָה instead of the actual תֵּבָה), but rather to the Egyptian ḏbʾt, meaning “chest,” “box,” “coffin.”^[630] In the Septuagint and the New Testament, Noah’s ark is called κιβωτός, “box,” “chest,” “coffer”; this term is applied also to the chest (Hebrew אֲרוֹן) placed at the entrance to the temple by Jehoiada, the priest (II Kings 12:10-11), and to the ark of the covenant (cf., e.g., Exod. 25:10 ff. and Heb. 9:4).

These comparisons show that as there is no etymological connection between the name of Noah and the Babylonian names for the hero of the flood, so there is none between the Hebrew term for the ark and the Babylonian designations for the same vessel.

The Old Testament deluge ark was made of gōfer wood. The meaning of this expression, found only in Gen. 6:14, is quite uncertain, although it is generally held to refer to some kind of resinous wood, such as pine or cypress. The Hebrew gōfer is hardly derived from the Babylonian and Aesyrian gipâru, which in some passages appears to denote some kind of tree or shrub. Gipâru is a loan-word from Sumerian. Consequently, if gōfer were etymologically related to gipâru, it would likewise have to be a loan-word, either from Sumerian directly or from Babylono-Assyrian. In that case, however, we should expect a form something like gifār in Hebrew. As a loan-word from Babylonian, the term gōfer would presuppose a form like gupru (cf. Babylonian kupru and Hebrew kōfer), which has actually been found in two or three passages, but in the sense of “table.”^[631] In the preserved portions of the Babylonian deluge traditions nothing is said about the kind of wood that was used for the construction of the boat.

Utnapishtim’s vessel had seven stories and was divided vertically into nine sections, thus having sixty-three compartments (Tablet XI:60-62). Its roof was like that of “the subterranean waters,” i.e., it was as strong as the earth, which holds the subterranean waters in their place (Tablet XI:31).^[632] According to the Semitic Nippur fragment, the boat was topped with “a strong cover.” It had a door (Tablet XI:88.93) and at least one window (XI:135). Noah’s ark, on the other hand, had three stories and consisted of numerous unspecified cells, or compartments. It had a door in its side and an opening for light below the roof (Gen. 6:16). The Hebrew term used to designate the opening for light is ṣōhar. This word has been equated with Arabic ẓahrun and

Babylonian ṣîru, both meaning “back,” and has been taken to refer to the roof of the ark.^[633] But if ṣōhar really meant “roof,” the addition “above” or “from above,” in Gen. 6:16, would be quite superfluous, inasmuch as it is self-evident that the roof is “above.” Moreover, the specification “to a cubit” would be meaningless.^[634] From these considerations and the references to a window in Gen. 8:6^[635] and the main Babylonian account of the flood, it is reasonably certain that the term in question denotes an opening for light. This opening was one cubit in height and, according to the prevalent explanation, extended all around the ark, interrupted only by the posts supporting the roof. This interpretation seems to be favored by the wording of the text: “Thou shalt make an opening for light for the ark and to a cubit shalt thou make it complete from above.” This passage seems to indicate that Noah is to construct an opening for light completely around the ark.^[636]

The Old Testament ark was coated inside and out with pitch, or bitumen, to make it watertight. Bituminous materials figure more prominently in the main Babylonian account than they do in the biblical. Utnapishtim poured six (var.: three) shar of pitch into the furnace, or pitch pot, and three shar of asphalt. The purpose is not stated, but there can be no doubt about it—he melted these substances and then calked the boat therewith. This is quite clear from Berossus’ statement: “Some get pitch from the ship by scraping (it) off.” The word for pitch, as we shall see later on, is the same both in Genesis and in the Gilgamesh Epic. In addition to these materials, Utnapishtim used three shar of oil, which the basket-carriers brought. Of this oil, one shar was used presumably to saturate the water-stoppers; the other two shar the boatman stowed away, for unspecified purposes (Tablet XI:65-69). The use of oil is not mentioned in the biblical narrative.

Noah’s ark, as evidenced by its dimensions and the names by which it is designated in Greek and Hebrew, was of flat-bottomed, rectangular construction, square on both ends and straight up on the sides. Such a craft is represented on bronze coins from the Phrygian city Apameia, which already at the time of Caesar Augustus bore the cognomen Κιβωτός, distinguishing it from other cities of the same name in Bithynia and Syria. To the right these coins, dating from the reign of Septimius Severus (a.d. 146-211) on down and betraying doubtless Jewish influence, picture an open chest swimming in the water and bearing the inscription ΝΩΕ or simply ΝΩ. In the chest are seen the deluge hero and his wife, both appearing from the waist upward. On the raised lid of the ark a dove is perched, while another comes flying toward the ark with a twig in its claws. To the left the same pair of human beings are seen but standing on dry ground and raising their right hands in adoration.^[637]

The length of Noah’s ark was “three hundred cubits, its breadth fifty cubits, and its height thirty cubits” (Gen. 6:15). Since the cubit is here given without any qualifying addition, it probably represents the ordinary Hebrew cubit, which supposedly corresponded to the distance from the tip of the middle finger to the elbow and measured about 18 inches. According to this standard, the ark was 450 feet long, 75 feet wide, and 45 feet high, and had a displacement of approximately 43,300 tons.

Utnapishtim's boat, on the contrary, was an exact cube, the length, width, and height each being 120 cubits. Since the Babylonian cubit was equal to about 20 inches, 120 cubits correspond to about 200 feet. The Babylonian vessel, accordingly, had a displacement of about 228,500 tons. The shape and the manner of construction of Utnapishtim's boat are strongly reminiscent of the guffa, a kind of coracle made of wickerwork and coated inside and out with bitumen. But, contrary to the view expressed by King,^[638] it is by no means identical with this circular craft, which is still in constant use on the lower Tigris and Euphrates. Tablet XI:30 and 57-58, which instructs Utnapishtim that the length and the width of the boat should be equal and which then gives the exact height of its walls and the exact length of each side of its deck, refers to a quadrangular craft. King's argument that the boat's interior division of each story into nine vertical sections "is only suitable to a circular craft in which the interior walls would radiate from the center" overlooks the possibilities that the compartments may have extended from side to side,^[639] or that Utnapishtim may have built in four walls, two of which ran in one direction and two in another, crossing at right angles to make nine square rooms on each floor.^[640]

Berossus speaks of a boat over 3,000 feet long and more than 1,200 feet wide. The height of this fabulous vessel is not given.

There is thus a decided variance between the dimensions of the boat as contained in the Babylonian traditions and those given in Genesis. But all accounts agree that the hero of the deluge was divinely ordered to construct the vessel in which—to borrow a phrase from the Babylonian versions—"the seed of all living creatures" was saved from the waters of the great flood that covered the earth. Moreover, the Atraḫasis Epic (Fragment III) would seem to indicate that the god who disclosed the imminent calamity even drew a plan of the boat. The detailed instructions which Noah received amounted to about the same thing. According to Tablet XI, Utnapishtim himself appears to have drawn up the necessary plans.

The Occupants of the Ark

Upon the completion of his craft, Utnapishtim loaded aboard it all his gold and silver and whatever he had of "the seed of all living creatures," and caused all his family and relations, "the game of the field, the beasts of the field, all the craftsmen," and the boatman to go up into it (Tablet XI:80-85 and 94-95). The craftsmen (or learned men) were taken aboard undoubtedly for the same reason for which, according to Berossus, Xisuthros was ordered before the deluge "to set down in writing the beginning, middle, and end of all things," and to bury these writings in Sippar—in order to preserve the divine revelations concerning the origin of the world and to transmit the arts and sciences, human culture, and civilization to the postdiluvian race.^[641]

The last preserved line of column v of the fragmentary Sumerian account shows that Ziusudra took at least sheep and cattle with him into the boat, for after the flood he killed an ox and offered an abundant sacrifice of sheep. According to the Atraḫasis Epic, the deluge hero put into

the ark his grain, his goods and chattels, his family, his relations, the craftsmen, "[game] of the field (and) beasts of the field, as many as eat herbs" (Fragment III). The preserved portion of the Semitic Nippur fragment refers only to "the beasts of the field" and "the fowl of the heavens." That Utnapishtim likewise took birds with him into the ark is apparent from the fact that after the landing of the ark he sent out a dove, a swallow, and a raven to ascertain to what degree the waters had fallen (Tablet XI:145-54). Berossus relates that Xisuthros went aboard the ship with "his relatives," his "wife and children, and his close friends" and that he stored up in it "food and drink" and "put into it also living creatures, winged and four-footed." A reference to the storing-up of food supplies is perhaps found also on Tablet XI:64: "I provided punting-poles and stored up a supply." These documents seem to indicate that the Babylonian hero of the flood took only herbivorous animals with him.

In contrast with the great number of people who were saved according to the Babylonian diluvial traditions, the biblical ark carried only eight persons, viz., Noah, his three sons, his wife, and the wives of his sons. With respect to the preservation of animal life Noah received the following instruction, according to Gen. 6:19-21: "Of every living thing, of all flesh, thou shalt bring two of every (species) into the ark to keep (them) alive with thee; they shall be a male and a female. Of the birds after their species and of the beasts after their species, of all the creeping things of the earth after their species; two of every (species) shall come unto thee to keep (them) alive. And thou shalt take unto thee of every (kind of) food that is eaten and shalt gather (it) unto thee; and it shall be food for thee and for them." In Gen. 7:2-3 this general rule is amplified and a distinction is made between clean and unclean animals: "Of all clean beasts thou shalt take unto thee seven pairs, the male and its mate; but of the beasts that are not clean (only) two, the male and its mate; likewise, of the birds of the air seven pairs,^[642] the male and its mate, to keep seed alive upon the face of all the earth." The story then continues: "And Noah, with his sons, his wife, and the wives of his sons, went into the ark, because of the waters of the flood. Of the clean beasts and of the beasts that are not clean, of the birds and of everything that creeps upon the earth they went to Noah into the ark in pairs,^[643] the male and (its) mate, as God had commanded Noah" (vss. 7-9).

A question frequently asked in this connection is how the gathering-in of the animals took place. According to the Atraḫasis Epic, Fragment III, the animals came by divine guidance, for Ea told Atraḫasis: "[Game] of the field (and) beasts of the field, as many as eat herbs, [I will s]end unto thee." This appears to be the import also of Gen. 6:19-20: "Of every living thing, of all flesh, thou shalt bring into (lit.: cause to come into) the ark two of every (species) to keep (them) alive with thee: they shall be a male and a female. Of the birds after their species and of the beasts after their species, of all the creeping things of the earth after their species; two of every (species) shall come unto thee to keep (them) alive." The natural meaning seems to be that these creatures would come voluntarily to Noah and that he should then put them in the ark.

The Day of the Beginning of the Flood

“In the six hundredth year of Noah’s life, in the second month, on the seventeenth day of the month, on that very day all the fountains of the great deep (tēhôm) were broken open, and the windows of the heavens were opened” (Gen. 7:11). In trying to determine the time of the year when the flood burst upon mankind, we are at once confronted with the problem of identifying “the second month.” Scholars have debated this point from the earliest times, and still there is no unanimity among them. Some hold that the months are here reckoned from the commencement of the agricultural year among the Hebrews, which started in the autumn (cf. Exod. 23:16; 34:22), so that “the second month” would refer to the second harvest month, known as Bûl or Marcheshwan and corresponding to the latter part of our October and the first part of November, when the rainy season in Palestine began.^[644] Others, counting the months of the year from the spring (cf. Exod. 12:2), understand “the second month” as the second spring month, called Ziw or Iyyar, which corresponds to the latter part of April and the early part of May, when the Tigris and Euphrates, following the melting of the snow in the mountains of Armenia and Kurdistan, reach their highest point of inundation.^[645] The evidence is so meager on both sides that it is rather difficult to reach a definite conclusion on this matter. According to Berossus, the date which the gods had set for the commencement of the flood was “the fifteenth of the month Daisios.” This month is derived from the Macedonian calendar and corresponds approximately to our May.^[646] The available cuneiform material is silent on the point in question.

The Causes of the Flood

The causes which the Genesis version assigns to the diluvial catastrophe are torrential rains from heaven and the eruption of the subterranean waters (7:11-12). The destructive forces listed on the Sumerian tablet are the amaru, meaning “rainstorm,” “rain flood,” or “cloudburst,”^[647] and mighty winds. These two elements, accompanied by thunder and lightning, are mentioned again in the Gilgamesh Epic, where they are referred to under the designations shamûtu kibâti, “destructive rain,” shâru, “wind,” meḫû, “tempest,” “southstorm(?),” râdu, “downpour,” abûbu, “rainstorm,” or “rain flood,” and imḫullu, “evil wind,” or “storm.” In addition, there is a reference to the breaking of the dikes of the canals and reservoirs, which was caused by the violent rise of the rivers (Tablet XI:90-131).

Berossus, in his description of the deluge, employs the term κατακλυσμός, “flood,” “inundation.” In the sense of “flood” or “deluge,” this word is used of the Deucalionic flood, caused by heavy rains.^[648] In the Septuagint and the New Testament it almost invariably corresponds to the Hebrew mabbûl, by which the deluge is designated in the Hebrew Old Testament.^[649] The excerpt by Abydenus attributes the catastrophe to “copious rains” (πλῆθος οὐμβρων). This is supported, moreover, by his statement that, “after the rain had subsided” (ἐπεί τε ὕων ἐκόπασε), Sisisthros released a number of birds to test the conditions of the outside world.

King, in his effort to defend the position that the deluge was caused by the annual overflow of the Tigris and the Euphrates, argued that abûbu should properly be rendered "flood," adding: "In itself the term abûbu implies flood, which could take place through a rise of the rivers unaccompanied by heavy local rain."^[650] However, there does not appear to be any decisive evidence that abûbu was ever employed to denote also an inundation caused by the rivers unaccompanied by heavy rains; to designate a river-flood, or a high tide of water, the Babylonians used mêlû or edû. But even should such evidence be available, it still does not alter the fact that the Babylonian versions very definitely attribute the deluge to a heavy storm. This phenomenon is emphasized with special force in column v of the Sumerian version and on Tablet XI:90-131 of the Gilgamesh Epic. Neither of these passages sounds anything like a description of an inundation due merely to an overflow of the rivers. According to the latter passage, the flood was caused principally by "the raging of Adad," the god of storm and rain, who had nothing to do with the periodic rising of the rivers in Mesopotamia. On Tablet XI:131, where it is said that "the flood (abûbu) ceased" simultaneously with the quieting of the sea and the cessation of the storm, the abûbu quite obviously signifies the heavy downpour of rain and not the inundation caused by it and at that time still covering the earth.^[651] In like manner mabbûl in Gen. 7:17: "The flood (mabbûl) came^[652] upon the earth forty days, and the waters mounted," evidently refers to the unprecedented stream of rain coming down from above, without including the resultant inundation, which continued for a long time afterward, as we shall see shortly.^[653]

Toward the end of the last century, the eminent geologist Eduard Suess,^[654] of Vienna, endeavoring to rationalize the Babylonian flood story and realizing the insufficiency of the inundation theory alone, advanced the view that the deluge was caused chiefly by gigantic sea waves produced partly by seismic disturbances "in the region of the Persian Gulf, or to the south of it" and partly by a cyclone or hurricane, which, arising from the Bay of Bengal, crossed India and then traveled north through the Persian Gulf and, at the height of the annual inundation, during the period of the most violent shocks of the earthquake, which caused the subterranean waters to burst forth from the fissured plain, swept over the Tigro-Euphrates area, damming back the waters of the rivers and driving before it stupendous masses of water from the sea, accompanied by torrents of rain. The deluge as a whole, however, Suess contended, came from the sea; the rain and the subterranean waters, as well as the regular overflow of the rivers, were "merely accessory elements."

In support of this view, Suess invoked both the biblical and the main Babylonian flood story, from which he believed the former to have been borrowed. To prove his contention that the deluge resulted in part from an earthquake, he appealed to the mention of the breaking-up of the fountains of the deep in the biblical text and to a number of features derived from quite untenable translations of the Babylonian material. With his arguments drawn from the Babylonian material, we need not concern ourselves in this instance. Elaborating on the biblical statement, Suess declared that the "rising of great quantities of water from the deep is a phenomenon which is a characteristic accompaniment of earthquakes in the alluvial districts of great

rivers."^[655] Again: "Such phenomena have never been observed on any great scale except in extensive low-lying districts, where subterranean water is present, nor would they be explicable under any other conditions."^[656]

Since one of the earthquake zones in the world runs along the east and north of the Persian Gulf and stretches across Mesopotamia,^[657] the Babylonians could perhaps have connected the deluge with terrestrial convulsions; but in all the extant diluvial traditions from Babylonia—whether composed in Sumerian, Semitic Babylonian, or Greek—there is not the faintest trace of such a phenomenon. According to the biblical narrative, on the other hand, the flood was evidently accompanied by a most violent earthquake."^[658] But whether the import of the story is that the breaking-up of the fountains of the deep occurred only in the alluvial plains of the earth is quite a different question. Since the Genesis account is full of the miraculous or the supernatural, and since according to it the flood was universal, the statement, "All the fountains of the great deep were broken up" (7:11), obviously carries the implication that the subterranean waters gushed forth everywhere, irrespective of the condition of the terrain.

Suess's further assertion that the flood as a whole was of marine origin rests, in part, on a change imported into the Hebrew text. Following J. D. Michaelis and others, Suess modified the vocalization of the Hebrew phrase hammabbûl ma(y)yim, "the flood (of) waters" (Gen. 6:17 and 7:6), making the words read instead hammabbûl miyyām, which the proponents of this alteration translated "the flood from the sea."^[659] The biblical text was thus, so it seemed, in perfect accord with his position. However, the proposed emendation is rendered improbable by similar expressions in Gen. 7:7 and 9:11-15, where ma(y)yim cannot be changed to miyyām, and, as observed by K. Budde,^[660] is ruled out by the consideration that instead of miyyām the Hebrew text would have to read min-hayyām.^[661]

Finally, the idea of a cyclone, serving as a further support for his view that the deluge was produced primarily by a raging sea, was inferred by Suess from the course taken by the ship in the main Babylonian story; for he observed that after the flood Utnapishtim's craft, traveling against the natural current of the water in Babylonia, is found over two hundred miles north of Shurippak, its starting-point. In this, Suess saw conclusive evidence for a cyclone originating in the vicinity of the Andaman Islands, in the Bay of Bengal.^[662] These cyclones, or hurricanes, are among the most terrific in the world. "Travelling more or less westwards or northwards, to quote the words of another geologist, W. J. Sollas,^[663] they "sweep over the waters of the bay of Bengal, and raise the sea into waves mountains high, which every now and again rush over the low-lying lands of the Ganges delta, overwhelming the unfortunate inhabitants by the myriads." But, as Sollas continues, "these storms do not, as a rule, travel towards the Persian gulf, and the North Arabian sea is singularly free from them." Suess himself is unable to point to a single instance where one of these cyclones is known to have entered the Persian Gulf. This is a serious blow to his theory. To remove the difficulty, Suess assumed that for once such a storm lost its way, so to speak, and actually traveled through the Persian Gulf and reached the

Mesopotamian Valley. Since the Babylonian deluge version imbedded in the Gilgamesh Epic speaks of a heavy storm and since the severest atmospheric disturbances in Babylonia arise in the south, it seems to be a natural conclusion that the boat was driven by a violent storm from the southern sea, which kept the boat from drifting into the Persian Gulf and, instead, drove it from Shurippak all the way to Mount Niṣir, about 270 miles north.^[664] But the storm need not have been the kind suggested by the famous geologist. Furthermore, there is no evidence that the storm was believed to have caused an inundation from the sea.^[665] On the contrary, the fact that Ea, the god who presided at least over the waters at the northern end of the Persian Gulf,^[666] is nowhere mentioned as having taken part in the actual causation of the deluge makes it doubtful whether the thought of an incursion of the sea was really in the minds of the Babylonian mythographers. It is therefore manifest that the incursion of the sea, if this element was at all present, can have played only a secondary role and that the real source of the flood was rain.

The Duration of the Flood

Modern biblical criticism, as is well known, sees in the Genesis account of the deluge a blending of two main, in several respects irreconcilably contradictory, sources put together by a redactor. According to the one source, called P (or the Priestly Code), the flood began on the seventeenth day of the second month (7:11) and ended on the twenty-seventh day of the second month of the following year (8:13-14), the whole occurrence thus extending over a period of one year and eleven days. But according to the other source, called J (or the Yahwistic Narrative), it rained for forty days and forty nights (7:12), at the end of which Noah opened the window of the ark and sent forth four birds at intervals of three successive periods of seven days (8:6-12), whereupon he removed the covering of the ark and found that the face of the ground was dry (vs. 13b); accordingly, the duration of the flood was only sixty-one days.

With this view I cannot agree. However, this is not the place to enter upon a detailed discussion of the problems involved; a few words will have to suffice. I do by no means deny that a number of different documents may have been utilized in the composition of the biblical flood story, for the Scriptures themselves indicate unmistakably that the sacred penmen employed written records and the like in the preparation of their books. But, in spite of the claims that have been made, I am not at all convinced that the biblical material can be resolved into its constituent elements with any degree of certainty. Moreover, I am not in sympathy with the common practice of treating the alleged remnants of each supposed document as if it constituted the whole, with the result that the Genesis account of the deluge, with which alone we are at present concerned, fairly teems with discrepancies. It must be apparent to every unprejudiced reader that the Genesis version of the flood, as divided by modern biblical criticism, shows several important gaps in the portions assigned to J and P. Therefore, if we had access to the complete text of the supposed documents denominated J and P (assuming, for the sake of argument, that such documents ever existed), we might see at once that there were no discrepancies at all between

the two. But even without such access, it has been demonstrated repeatedly that the alleged contradictions in the Genesis narrative are capable of a simple and reasonable solution if the story is left as we find it in the Hebrew text.

A good illustration of this we have in the point under examination—the duration of the flood. If we leave the biblical text as it stands and treat the story as one whole, the numerical data on the duration of the deluge are in perfect harmony, as shown by the following.

According to 7:11, the flood began in the six hundredth year of Noah's life, on the seventeenth day of the second month, coming seven days after Noah had received the command to enter the ark (7:1-4.10). For forty days and forty nights it rained upon the earth (vs. 12). It is not said anywhere that after this period the downpour stopped altogether. On the contrary, the rain and the gushing-forth of the subterranean springs continued; for it is clearly stated that the fountains of the deep and the windows of heaven were not closed and that the rain from heaven was not stopped (וַיִּכָּלֵא)^[667] until the end of the one hundred and fiftieth day after the outbreak of the flood, for which reason the waters kept rising or maintained their maximum height during all this time (7:24-8:2). But while the flow of the subterranean waters may have continued with great force even after the first forty days, the uninterrupted and unrestrained torrential downpour from heaven must have ceased and the rain must have continued much more moderately, for we read in 7:12: "The rain came upon the earth forty days and forty nights," and in verse 17: "The flood (mabbûl) came upon the earth forty days." As pointed out before, the term mabbûl in verse 17 undoubtedly describes the unprecedented stream of rain from above, which made the waters mount on the surface of the earth. From this it seems quite obvious that it was the unchecked torrential rain or the sheets of water from the sky which ceased after the first forty days.^[668]

At the end of the 150 days the waters began to decrease (8:3), and on the seventeenth day of the seventh month the ark rested on one of the mountains of Ararat (vs. 4). This was exactly 5 months and 1 day from the beginning of the flood (cf. 7:11). The obvious conclusion appears to be that the 150 days constituted 5 months and that each month, consequently, consisted of 30 days. On the day that the waters began to abate, i.e., on the one hundred and fifty-first day from the commencement of the flood, the ark grounded. The waters continued to decrease until, on the first day of the tenth month, the tops of the mountains became visible (8:5). If a month is reckoned at 30 days, this gives us 74 additional days, yielding a total of 225 days. At the end of 40 days from this date, i.e., the first of the tenth month, Noah opened the window of the ark and sent forth four birds at intervals of three successive periods of 7 days (vss. 6-12). Since the first bird was released on the forty-first day, these figures add up to 62 more days and bring the total up to 287 days. The last bird was sent forth on the two hundred and eighty-seventh day from the beginning of the deluge, or (adding the 46 days of the year which elapsed before the outbreak of the flood) on the three hundred and thirty-third day of the year. We have, accordingly, arrived at the third day of the twelfth month. Twenty-eight days later, on the first day of the following

year, in the six hundred and first year of Noah's life, the waters were dried up from off the earth (but the surface of the ground was not yet fully dry) and Noah removed the covering of the ark (vs. 13). A month and 26 days after that, on the twenty-seventh of the second month, the earth was again dry and firm, and Noah left the ark (vss. 14 ff.). These two periods amount to 84 days. Adding these days to the 287, we gain a grand total of 371 days, or 1 year and 11 days, beginning with the outbreak of the flood. There is here no discrepancy whatever.^[669]

The year in which the flood came upon mankind, according to the biblical data, apparently consisted of only 360 days, the reckoning being neither by lunar years of 354 days nor by solar years of 365 days. This year, accordingly, seems to have fallen 5 or 6 days short of our calendrical year. However, it may well be that 5 extra days were added at the end of the year, so that 94 instead of 89 days elapsed between the first of the tenth month (8:5) and the beginning of the following year (vs. 13), the whole period from the entry into the ark to the disembarkation thus lasting 376 days. The latter calendaric system would find its parallel in Egypt and the former in Babylonia. The Egyptian calendar, which is probably followed in the Genesis story, had 12 months of 30 days each, adding up to 360 days. But to these were added 5 days at the end, which produced a rough conformity with the solar year. The Babylonians, on the other hand, with their lunar calendar of 29 and 30 days to the month, equalized the difference by a cyclic intercalation of an additional month. But alongside the real lunar calendar, they had also, already in early Babylonian times, "a schematic calendar of 12 months of 30 days each, regardless of the real moon," the year thus having only 360 days.^[670]

According to the Sumerian version, the flood raged for seven days and seven nights, at the end of which the sun-god came forth and shed his light over heaven and earth (col. v). In the Gilgamesh Epic it is stated that a destructive rain in the evening began the deluge and was followed at the break of day by a terrific storm lasting six days and six nights. "When the seventh day arrived, the tempest, the flood, which had fought like an army, subsided in (its) onslaught. The sea grew quiet, the storm abated, the flood ceased." And after an unspecified number of days, Utnapishtim and those with him left the boat (Tablet XI:90-156). The excerpt from Berossus is silent on the duration of the deluge.

The Magnitude and Effect of the Flood

The magnitude of the storm and its appalling effect are described in forceful terms in the main Babylonian recension of the deluge. "As soon as the first shimmer of morning beamed forth, a black cloud came up from out the horizon." Adad, god of storm and rain, thundered within it. Irragal, god of the underworld, pulled out the masts. Ninurta, god of the wells and the irrigation works, came along and caused the dikes to burst. The Anunnaki, the judges in the underworld, raised their flaming torches, "lighting up the land with their brightness; the raging of Adad reached unto heaven (and) turned into darkness all that was light," so that "no man could see his fellow." The tempest raged in all its fury and apparently assumed greater dimensions than many

of the gods had anticipated, for, terror-stricken at the frightful cataclysm, they fled to the highest heaven and cowered like dogs in their distress! Ishtar, the lovely voiced lady of the gods, cried out like a woman in travail and lamented: “In truth, the olden time has turned to clay, because I commanded evil in the assembly of the gods! How could I command (such) evil in the assembly of the gods! (How) could I command war to destroy my people, (for) it is I who bring forth (these) my people! Like the spawn of fish they (now) fill the sea!” (118-23). Even the Anunnaki, who had helped to spread terror and destruction among mankind, wept with her. “The gods sat bowed (and) weeping. Covered were their lips.” When at last, after six days and six nights, the storm had exhausted its force and the flood ceased, Utnapishtim opened a window and looked upon the sea caused by the unprecedented storm. What he beheld was heartbreaking—“(All) was silence, and all mankind had turned to clay.” Moved to tears by the complete desolation round about, he “looked in (all) directions for the boundaries of the sea. At (a distance of) twelve (double-hours)^[671] there emerged a stretch of land.” This turned out to be Mount Niṣir, on which afterward the boat grounded. This mountain had either not been covered at all by the flood or only lightly so that it reappeared immediately upon the abatement of the water. But all the rest, at least in that part of the world, was one vast expanse of sea. The impression which this story is intended to make obviously is that the flood was universal and that all the land animals and all mankind perished, except the occupants of the ark. The other Babylonian deluge traditions convey the same general impression.

According to the Genesis account, the fountains of the abyss broke open and the windows of heaven were opened; for forty days and forty nights the waters gushed forth from below and poured down in torrents from above. “The waters increased and lifted the ark, so that it rose above the earth. And the waters grew mighty and increased greatly upon the earth, so that the ark floated on the face of the waters. And the waters grew exceedingly strong upon the earth; and all the high mountains under the whole heaven were covered. Fifteen cubits above (them) the waters rose, so that the mountains were covered. And all flesh perished that moved upon the earth, the fowl, the beasts, the game, every creeping thing that creeps upon the earth, and all mankind. Everything died in whose nostrils was the breath of the spirit of life, namely, everything that was on the dry land. Every creature was wiped off the face of the earth, from mankind to the beasts, to the creeping things, and the fowl of the heavens; they were wiped off the earth, so that Noah alone was left and those with him in the ark” (7:17-23). This account, like the main Babylonian story, plainly asserts the universality of the deluge.

The Landing-Place of the Ark

The place on which Utnapishtim’s boat came to rest is given in the Gilgamesh Epic as Mount Niṣir, which signifies the “Mount of Salvation,” if our reading is correct and if the name is of Semitic origin. Such a mountain, or mountain range, is recorded in the annals of King Ashurnasirpal II of Assyria (883-859 b.c.), according to which it was situated to the south of the Lower Zab and is probably to be identified with Pir Omar Gudrun, having an altitude of about

9,000 feet.^[672] Berossus names the mountains of the Gordyaeans, or the Kurds, as the landing-place of the boat of Xisuthros. These mountains, corresponding to Jebel Jûdî, where also Syriac and Arabic traditions localize the landing-place, are in the southwestern part of Armenia. The Genesis account is quite indefinite on the point under consideration, stating merely that the ark grounded "on (one of) the mountains of Araraṭ." The name Araraṭ is identical with the Assyrian Urarṭu, which, broadly speaking, embraced the territory of Armenia. In three of the four Old Testament passages where the word Ararat occurs, the Septuagint has simply transliterated it (Gen. 8:4; II Kings 19:37; Jer. 51:27 [28:27 in the Septuagint]), while in the remaining passage the translators have rendered it with "Armenia" (Isa. 37:38). Since it is believed that the ark rested on the highest peak in the country it has long been customary to identify the landing-place with Mount Massis (or Agridagh), situated a little northeast of Lake Van and rising to approximately 17,000 feet above sea-level. Evidently through a misunderstanding of Gen. 8:4, this elevation has traditionally been called Mount Araraṭ.^[673]

The Bird Scene

On the seventh day after the landing of the boat on Mount Niṣir, Utnapishtim released a dove for the purpose of testing the subsidence of the water. But since the dove found no resting-place, she returned. After an unspecified interval, he sent forth a swallow, which likewise returned. Finally he sent out a raven. The raven ate, flew about, and cawed, but did not return.

The extracts from the account of Berossus also mention the sending-out of the birds on three different occasions, but they fail to state how many and what kinds of birds were used for the experiment. According to the longer and more detailed excerpt, Berossus says that, as soon as the flood ceased, "Xisuthros let go some birds..... But as they found no food nor a place to alight, they returned to the ship. After certain days Xisuthros again let the birds go; these again returned to the ship, but with their feet muddy. But when they were let go for the third time, they did not again return to the ship."

The Book of Genesis describes the episode of the birds at considerable length. Forty days after the tops of the other mountains had become visible, Noah opened the window of the ark and sent forth a raven (8:5-7). The wild, omnivorous bird went flying back and forth, sometimes away from the ark and sometimes back to it again, until the waters had dried off the earth, but he did not again go into the ark. He presumably found some carrion meat floating in the water or deposited on the mountaintops, or some aquatic creatures trapped on the mountain peaks as the water receded, and this provided sufficient sustenance for the unclean raven with his carrion-eating propensities. The raven's failure to return into the ark does not show that he proved himself useless for the intended purpose and that the experiment was unsuccessful.^[674] To the contrary, it was a good sign; for it proved that the waters had

declined considerably and that even though the outside world was still very unfriendly or inhospitable, it was no longer too inhospitable for so sturdy and unfastidious a bird as the raven.^[675]

After seven days Noah let a dove fly out, "to see whether the waters had subsided from the surface of the land; but the dove found no resting-place for the sole of her foot, so she returned to him into the ark; for there was (still) water upon the surface of the whole earth. Then he put forth his hand, and took her, and drew her into the ark with him" (8:8-9). The dove, unlike the raven, is a gentle, timid, and more particular bird, which will not feed on carcasses; it loves valleys and dislikes mountains (Ezek. 7:16). Although the waters had abated considerably by this time, revealing many a mountain peak, the dove found no resting-place agreeable to her; so she returned. This was an indication that the lowlands were still covered.

Having waited seven more days, Noah released another dove, which did not come back until toward evening. The second dove had evidently found food and a resting-place, but the conditions of the outside world was still such that the dove preferred to spend the night in the ark. On her return, she brought an olive leaf in her bill. It was not a withered leaf, nor one that had been floating on the water, but "a freshly plucked" leaf (8:10-11). Since the olive tree does not grow at great altitudes, Noah had proof that the waters of the flood had fallen roughly to the level of the olive trees in the lowlands. That the olive tree was found also in Armenia we know from the Greek geographer and historian Strabo (ca. 63 b.c.-ca. a.d. 23).^[676]

After another seven days, Noah sent out a third dove, but she never returned (8:12). Also this was a good sign; it showed that the lowlands as well as the mountains were free of water.

A comparison of these stories reveals that they are in agreement on the main points with regard to the bird episode. All agree that the hero of the flood, after the subsidence of the storm, sent out a number of birds to secure information concerning the conditions of the outside world. While the purpose of this experiment is not expressly stated in the Babylonian legends, it can be inferred without difficulty from the course of subsequent events. But the Hebrew and Babylonian versions differ very decidedly in the matter of details. The Babylonian stories speak of three trials, the biblical of four. Utnapishtim and Noah release one bird on each occasion, whereas Xisuthros lets go a number of them each time. Utnapishtim sends out a dove, a swallow, and a raven; Noah releases a raven and three doves. The biblical account contains no reference to the swallow, which is well known in Palestine and is mentioned in the Old Testament under the term sûs or sîs (Isa. 38:14; Jer. 8:7); perhaps also under the term dĕrôr (Ps. 84:4; Prov. 26:2). Noah begins with the raven, Utnapishtim ends the experiment with this bird. By releasing the raven first, Noah, whose wisdom is nowhere mentioned in the biblical account, displayed greater wisdom than Utnapishtim, who, notwithstanding the fact that he is called "the exceedingly wise," sent the raven out last. For what legitimate conclusions could Utnapishtim draw from the raven's failure to return after he had sent out the dove and the swallow? As is well known, he deduced

from it that the earth was dry enough for the occupants of the boat to disembark. This was a mistake in logic. However, as luck would have it, the earth turned out to be habitable again, and Utnapishtim's reputation was unimpaired.^[677] In addition to these, there are a number of other points of dissimilarity, such as the biblical reference to the olive leaf and the statement in Berossus that the second group of birds returned with mud adhering to their feet, both of which points find no parallels in the other narratives.

The Exit from the Ark

The disembarkation of the occupants of the deluge vessel receives but a passing notice in the Babylonian cuneiform sources. From the Sumerian version it can only be inferred, while, in the Gilgamesh Epic, Utnapishtim contents himself with the bare statement that he "sent forth (everything) to the four winds" when the raven failed to return. Berossus is somewhat more informative on this point. By him we are told that, when the last group of birds did not come back, Xisuthros concluded that land had appeared, whereupon he unstopped "a part of the seams of the ship and perceiving that the ship had grounded upon a certain mountain, he disembarked with (his) wife, (his) daughter, and the pilot"; all the others, who had remained behind, disembarked later, when Xisuthros and his companions failed to return.

The Genesis account treats the subject under examination with considerable circumstantiality. Almost two months after the waters of the flood had dried up, God said to Noah: "Go forth of the ark, thou and thy wife, thy sons and the wives of thy sons with thee. Bring forth with thee every living thing that is with thee, of all flesh, including the fowl and the beasts and every creeping thing that creeps upon the earth, that they may breed abundantly on the earth, and be fruitful and multiply on the earth" (8:16-17). In obedience to this command, "Noah went forth, and his sons and his wife and the wives of his sons with him. Every living thing, every creeping thing, every fowl, (and) everything that moves on the earth went forth out of the ark according to their families" (vss. 18-19).

It will be observed that Noah did not leave the ark until the ground was again fully dry and, so we may infer, until the plants had again grown sufficiently to support the parent-stock of the new world. The situation is different in the Babylonian versions. Since the flood, according to Babylonian traditions, was only of short duration, the ground and the plant life upon it were not thought to have been disturbed seriously. We notice, furthermore, that, while the Babylonian deluge hero, guided by the principle of self-help, disembarked on his own motion, Noah waited patiently for the express command of God to leave the ark. As he had entered the ark at the command of God, so he remained in it until he received divine orders to leave it. Utnapishtim, on the other hand, had entered the boat upon the instruction of a friendly deity (Tablet XI:86 ff.), but he disembarked at his own discretion. The biblical story is pervaded by the spirit of complete

submission to the will of God and complete dependence on him, while the Babylonian traditions reveal something of the spirit of self-determination and self-reliance, recalling those well-known lines of William Ernest Henley: “I am the master of my fate; I am the captain of my soul.”

The Sacrifice

In both the Babylonian and the Genesis accounts the deluge hero performed one or several acts of worship after his escape from the waters of the flood. Ziusudra prostrated himself before the sun-god and offered up an ox and an abundant sacrifice of sheep. He again fell down and worshiped when Anu Enlil made his appearance. The Sumerian story would seem to represent the sacrifice and at least the first adoration scene as having taken place on board the boat, while it was still floating on the waters. However, since this version constitutes probably an epitomized form of the deluge tradition, we cannot be certain about it. In all the other narratives the sacrifice and the act of prostration took place after the landing from the vessel. Utnapishtim offered a sacrifice, poured out a libation on the peak of the mountain, and burned fragrant materials —“(sweet) cane, cedar, and myrtle.” According to Berossus, Xisuthros prostrated himself to the ground, built an altar, and sacrificed to the gods. The biblical version closely parallels the Babylonian counterparts. Noah built an altar unto the Lord and offered burnt-offerings “of every clean beast and of every clean fowl” (8:20). The sacrifice was great, corresponding to the importance of the occasion.

The purpose of the offerings is naturally similar in all accounts. Since the Babylonian hero escaped against the will of the assembly of the gods, who had decreed the complete extermination of the human race, he had reason to fear the wrath of the gods, particularly that of Enlil, the instigator of the deluge; hence it is an obvious conclusion that his sacrifice was one of propitiation. However, as far as Utnapishtim’s attitude toward Ea was concerned, the offering was no doubt an expression of gratitude. The propitiatory character of the sacrifice is brought out quite clearly in the biblical narrative, where the ascending essence of the burnt-offerings is called a “soothing odor,” or, literally, an “odor of tranquilization” (8:21).^[678] One purpose of Noah’s sacrifice, as seems to be indicated by what follows, probably was to appease the wrath of God which had been kindled by the sins of mankind and which Noah had just witnessed. But at the same time it was undoubtedly an offering for the expiation of his own sins and those of his family. For even though Noah is characterized as righteous and faultless among his contemporaries (6:9), and even though 8:16-17, where he is told to leave the ark, contains no trace of any divine displeasure toward him or those with him, Noah was not absolutely perfect in the sight of God (cf. 8:21), and he was therefore in need of a sacrifice of atonement. On the other hand, since he had been delivered by the express will and help of God, there is no doubt at all that his sacrifice was a manifestation of deepest gratitude as well.

When the Lord “smelled the soothing odor” of the burnt-offerings and perceived the humble and grateful disposition of Noah’s heart and mind, his wrath in general subsided, and he resolved henceforth to bear with the sins of mankind and never again to visit the earth with a universal flood or to interrupt the course of nature as long as the earth endured (8:21-22).

A rather repugnant parallel to the last part of this episode we find in the main Babylonian deluge tradition. When “the gods smelled the sweet savor,” they “gathered like flies over the sacrificer.” Since through the extirpation of humankind, with the exception of the occupants of the ark, all sacrifices had ceased, the gods had not been fed for some weeks and now were hungry. In view of the opportunity of feasting again, all the gods and goddesses present apparently forgot their grievances against mankind and were glad that Utnapishtim had survived. Ishtar “lifted up the great jewels which Anu had made according to her wish (and said): ‘O ye gods here present, as surely as I shall not forget the lapis lazuli on my neck, I shall remember these days and shall not forget (them) ever! Let the gods come near to the offering; (but) Enlil shall not come near to the offering, because without reflection he brought on the deluge and consigned my people to destruction!’ ” (Tablet XI:163-69). When at last Enlil arrived, he was unaffected by the sacrifice. A quarrel ensued among the gods, in which Ea was accused of being responsible for Utnapishtim’s escape by having revealed the secret of the gods. But Ea turned from defender to accuser, condemning Enlil’s rash and indiscriminate destruction of the human family and upbraiding him for not having resorted to more reasonable measures to induce mankind to mend their ways. Enlil was moved by the reproach and had nothing to say in reply. Obviously, this was a silent admission that he had gone too far. His silence, together with the blessing which he subsequently pronounced upon Utnapishtim and his wife, doubtlessly implied also a resolve that the earth should never again be devastated by a catastrophe like the flood.

Divine Blessings

Enlil’s apparent change of heart is followed by a scene of rare beauty and great solemnity, contrasting sharply with the preceding episode. Enlil went up into the ship, took Utnapishtim by the hand, and caused him and his wife to go aboard and to kneel down; then, standing between them, he touched their foreheads and blessed them: “Hitherto Utnapishtim has been but a man; but now Utnapishtim and his wife shall be like unto us gods. In the distance, at the mouth of the rivers, Utnapishtim shall dwell!” (Tablet XI:193-95). According to Berossus, also their daughter and the boatman were translated to the society of the immortal gods. The Sumerian legend, on the contrary, speaks of only Ziusudra’s apotheosis, probably taking for granted that his wife shared in the same honor. Upon Enlil’s bestowal of divinity and immortality on Utnapishtim and his wife, the gods took them and caused them “to dwell in the distance, at the mouth of the rivers” (line 196).^[679] In the Sumerian version the flood hero was transferred to Dilmun. Some scholars have expressed the view that Dilmun was a country situated somewhere on the eastern shore of the Persian Gulf,^[680] while others have identified it with the Bahrein Islands (in the Persian Gulf),^[681] and still others with these islands and the neighboring coastland.^[682] On

the basis of the Sumerian text we are probably justified in assuming that by the expression “the mouth of the rivers” in the Gilgamesh Epic was meant originally the general area where in ancient times the Tigris and Euphrates flowed into the Persian Gulf through separate mouths. But that the phrase in question cannot refer to this region in the present form of the epic is clear from the fact that the epic pictures Utnapishtim as living in a faraway country and that Gilgamesh has to make a long and perilous journey over a virtually impassable mountain range and across a wide and dangerous sea before he arrives there. Scholars therefore incline to the view that in the course of time, as the Babylonians became better acquainted with the southern part of the land, the home of blessed Utnapishtim was transferred from “the place where the sun rises,” as the Sumerian version puts it, to a part of the world somewhere toward the setting of the sun, beyond the Mediterranean shore, and that this region was then designated as “the mouth of the rivers.”^[683] The excerpt from Berossus fixes the place of Xisuthros’ postdiluvian residence in heaven, adding that the flood hero was translated to the realm of the gods because of his piety.

The biblical account likewise speaks of a blessing imparted to the deluge hero, but it is of an altogether different nature. The blessing consists, in part, in the power—first conferred on man at the time of his creation and now bestowed anew on Noah and his sons—to multiply and fill the earth and to exercise dominion over the animals. Added to this is an extension of man’s right over the animals, legalizing the eating of their flesh. However, in order to prevent man’s degeneration to the level of barbarism and savagery, he is forbidden to eat their blood or the flesh with its blood. Moreover, while man is permitted to slaughter the animals for his consumption, he himself, being created in the image of God, may not be slain with impunity either by man or beast (Gen. 9:1-7). The blessing pronounced on the Babylonian hero included his removal from the ken of mortal man, but Noah remained in the company of those who, together with him, had escaped the waters of the great flood and lived for many years afterward.

The Conclusion of the Covenant

To date no real parallel has been discovered in any Babylonian diluvial tradition to the covenant which the Lord made with all flesh, including the animals, that the earth would never again be destroyed by a flood, or to the rainbow, the symbol of the covenant. However, Enlil’s presumed resolution that there should be no recurrence of such a catastrophe comes close to the biblical story of the covenant. Jensen,^[684] moreover, raised the question whether a parallel to the rainbow might not be found in the scene which portrays Ishtar as lifting up her azure-blue necklace and swearing that, as she would never forget these jewels, so she would never forget “these days,” evidently meaning the starvation days of the flood followed by the glorious day of the sacrifice (Tablet XI:162-65). Jensen’s idea, which he had advanced with much reserve, was subsequently adopted by Otto Weber^[685] with a high degree of confidence, while R. W. Rogers^[686] went another step further and accepted it as an established fact. But while Ishtar’s oath probably implied that she would never again consent to so terrible a destruction of

life and that the necklace was to serve as a reminder of her oath, as the rainbow is to remind the Lord of his promise to all flesh, the picture drawn in the Babylonian passage looks drab alongside what we find in the biblical story. The parallel becomes even less impressive when we consider that in the Mesopotamian version it was not Enlil, the head of the pantheon and the real author of the flood, who swore the oath, but Ishtar, a subordinate deity. It is interesting to note that as ardent a Pan-Babylonist as Heinrich Zimmern^[687] declined to accept Jensen's idea.

A New Creation of Humans after the Flood

The final column of Fragment IV of the Atraḫasis Epic records that Ea and Mami (or Mama), with the help of fourteen women, created fourteen human beings after the deluge. The reason for this new creation of human life was not that all mankind had perished in the flood, for Fragments II and III indicate quite definitely that this was not the case; in fact, the fourteen women participating in this act probably were themselves survivors of the flood. The purpose obviously was a speedy repopulation of the earth.

The new creation appears to have taken place in the following manner. Ea, the god of incantations and one of the creators of mankind, recited an incantation in the presence of Mami, the goddess of birth. At Ea's request, Mami then recited this same incantation over a lump of clay, whereupon she pinched off fourteen pieces of this clay and placed seven of them to the right and seven to the left and a brick (or brickwork) in between, probably as her symbol. She then called fourteen women who evidently had given birth before. These, apparently looking upon the pieces of clay, of which Mami seems to have modeled fourteen human beings, gave birth to seven boys and seven girls.^[688]

There is, of course, no parallel to this tale in the Genesis account of the flood. But there is a certain parallel in the Greek deluge tradition of Deucalion and Pyrrha, who were divinely directed to cast behind them "the bones of the great mother," i.e., the stones of the earth, to renew the human race, with the result that the stones thrown by Deucalion became men, while those thrown by Pyrrha, his wife, became women.^[689]

The Problem of Dependence

After the detailed examination of the points of contact between the Mesopotamian and Hebrew accounts of the flood it remains to inquire into their historical or genetic relationship. That the Babylonian and Hebrew versions are genetically related is too obvious to require proof; the only problem that needs to be discussed is the degree of relationship. Here, as in the case of the creation stories, three main possibilities have been suggested: first, the Babylonians borrowed from the Hebrew account; second, the Hebrew account is dependent on the Babylonian; third, both are descended from a common original.

The first explanation finds little favor among scholars today, since the earliest known tablets of the Babylonian legend are, upon any view of the date of the Book of Genesis, considerably older than the biblical narrative. The oldest dated tablets are the first two fragments of the Atraḫasis Epic, which were inscribed in the reign of Ammizaduga, the second-last king of the First Babylonian Dynasty. But, as attested by the scribal notation "a new break," on Fragment I, even the oldest available tablet is a copy of a still older original. Moreover, if the Atraḫasis Epic is based on Tablet XI, as suggested above ([p. 107]), it follows that the deluge version imbedded in the Gilgamesh Epic must antedate even the oldest recension of the Atraḫasis legend. All this is in perfect harmony with the fact that in all the Babylonian versions of the flood Enlil is still the chief god, while Marduk, who already in the days of Hammurabi was well on the way to supremacy among the gods,^[690] is not even mentioned on a single deluge tablet. We shall probably be safe in placing the date of the earliest written Babylonian account of the flood at the end of the third or the very beginning of the second millennium b.c. However, since priority of publication does not necessarily imply priority of existence, the argument derived from the age of the Babylonian account to disprove the originality of the Hebrew cannot be regarded as conclusive; the deluge version which we now call the Hebrew account of the flood may well have existed in some form or other many centuries before it assumed its present form.

The most widely accepted explanation today is the second, namely, that the biblical account is based on Babylonian material.

One of the foremost arguments advanced in support of this explanation is the contention that the coloring of the biblical account is distinctively Babylonian. A. H. Sayce declares: "The whole conception takes us back to the alluvial plain of Babylonia, liable at any time to be inundated by the waters of the Persian Gulf, and is wholly inapplicable to a mountainous country like Palestine, where rain only could have produced a flood."^[691] And Driver, following Zimmern, asserts: "The very essence of the Biblical narrative presupposes a country liable, like Babylonia, to inundations; so that it cannot be doubted that the story was 'indigenous in Babylonia, and transplanted to Palestine.' "^[692]

But this view, for which many more authorities could be quoted, finds no confirmation in the biblical text. In the biblical record there is not the slightest indication of an inundation caused by the rising of the rivers or the swelling of the sea. As we have observed, it mentions only torrential rains from heaven and the bursting of the subterranean fountains. Moreover, the first of these two elements is anything but characteristic of climatic conditions in Babylonia, while the second is by no means unknown in the West.

The average annual rainfall in Babylonia, amounting to about six inches, is quite inconsequential; were it not for the irrigation canals and the flooding of the rivers, Babylonia would be a barren desert. This condition has prevailed in Babylonia since time immemorial. In Palestine, by way of contrast, the mean annual rainfall is about four times as heavy, while in Syria it is from about six

to eight times as heavy.^[693] However, Friedrich Delitzsch,^[694] accepting the theory proposed by Suess, argued that when the Babylonian flood story had traveled to Palestine, the Hebrews, owing to the totally different conformation of their soil, "forgot that the sea had been the main factor." This assertion on the part of Delitzsch amounts to an attempt to prove one assumption by means of another. Although the deluge, according to the Gilgamesh Epic, was accompanied by a storm of extraordinary magnitude issuing probably from the Persian Gulf, there is no evidence, as we have seen, that the Babylonian tradition refers to an inundation from the sea; while, conversely, the idea of a flood caused by the descending rains is brought out in unmistakable terms. Had the deluge been due at least primarily to an incursion of the southern sea, the Babylonian mythographers should have made express mention of this point, instead of ignoring it and placing so much emphasis on the downfall of rain. To meet the last-named difficulty, G. A. Barton^[695] assumed that the rain, followed by a disastrously high overflow of the rivers, was stressed because it happened to be unusually heavy. This, of course, proves nothing but is a concession that such a rain does not reflect climatic conditions characteristic of Babylonia; an exceptionally heavy rain may occur anywhere and, therefore, does not point to any place in particular.^[696] The fact of the matter is that not even in the Babylonian flood stories do we have a true reflection of climatic conditions in Babylonia. For instead of ascribing the flood to the annual inundations caused by the rise of the rivers following the melting of the snows in the mountains of Armenia and Kurdistan, the Babylonian deluge traditions mentioning the cause of the cataclysm all agree that the real force of nature producing this unparalleled destruction was rain, even though Babylonia's annual rainfall is insignificant, as we have seen.

As for the springs of water, mentioned in the Genesis account, they figure much more conspicuously in Syria and Palestine, owing to the physical structure of the land, than they do in Babylonia. Palestine is appropriately described as "a land of brooks of water, of fountains and deaths (tēhômôth) that spring out of valleys and hills" (Deut. 8.7).^[697] In Babylonia, on the contrary, "springs do not gush from the earth,"^[698] i.e., normally. Furthermore, if, according to Suess, an earthquake in an alluvial region, such as Babylonia, causes a larger volume of water to burst forth than a terrestrial upheaval of equal magnitude would produce in an area like Syria-Palestine, must the story on this account have originated in a low-lying district? Since Syria-Palestine is a land of fountains, could not an earthquake of highly extraordinary violence—for it is a highly extraordinary seismic phenomenon that we must assume in either case, if we want to rationalize the flood story—cause sufficient subterranean water to erupt in this region to meet the description in Genesis? The fact that such eruptions have so far been observed on a large scale only in extensive low-lying parts of the world is no proof that under certain conditions they could not take place in the land of the Hebrews and their northern neighbors. Finally, is it not significant that not even the main Babylonian diluvial tradition, the most detailed of all the Mesopotamian accounts of the flood, contains as much as an allusion to the breaking-up of the fountains of the deep, particularly in view of the fact that it makes mention of such common manifestations as thunder and lightning?

In support of the view that the Genesis narrative reverts to the Babylonian account, attention has been called also to the bird episode. But we have seen that on this point, as in many other instances, the data of the biblical record are at a decided variance with those of the Babylonian versions; there are differences in the kind and number of birds and in the order in which they were released. Furthermore, as R. Andree has observed, the general idea of sending forth birds on the high seas for the purpose of obtaining information is met with also elsewhere in ancient literature and is not as extraordinary as it may seem at first.^[699] Pliny reports that the seafarers of Ceylon "take no observations of the stars in navigation" but "carry birds on board with them and at fairly frequent intervals set them free, and follow the course they take as they make for the land."^[700] It will also be recalled that the Argonauts sent forth a dove to determine whether or not they would be able to make their way to Pontus between the twin Cyanean rocks in their quest for the Golden Fleece.^[701]

Another argument for the priority of the Babylonian record has been derived from Gen. 8:21, which states that, as the Lord smelled the soothing odor of Noah's sacrifice, he determined that he would never again destroy all life by means of a flood. The first part of this passage has been said to be in literal agreement with Tablet XI:159-60: "The gods smelled the savor; the gods smelled the sweet savor."^[702] But—to begin with one of the least significant points—while the agreement between the two passages is undeniably close, the one cannot be regarded as a verbatim translation of the other. Rendered literally, the Babylonian lines read: "The gods smelled the odor; the gods smelled the good odor." Gen. 8:21a states: "And the Lord smelled the odor of tranquilization." The wording is not quite the same. Moreover, there is not a single etymological correspondence between the terms employed in the one version and those used in the other. But the main consideration against the above contention is the fact that Gen. 8:21a does not contain an element foreign to the Old Testament but one which is identical in thought and language with numerous other passages. Exactly the same phraseology is found in Lev. 26:31: "I will not smell the odor of your (offerings of) tranquilization." Much the same phrase occurs again in Amos 5:21: "I will not smell (the offerings) in your solemn assemblies," and in I Sam. 26:19: "Let Him smell an offering." The same idea we meet again in the ever recurring phrase of the ritual "a sweet savor unto the Lord," or, literally, "an odor of tranquilization unto the Lord" (cf. esp. Leviticus, chaps. I ff.). Nor can it be demonstrated that this concept first entered the Hebrew mind with the flood story. The argument based on Gen. 8:21 to prove the Babylonian origin of the biblical deluge account has no foundation whatever.

Perhaps the most important point which has been urged in favor of the explanation that the biblical story rests on Babylonian exemplars is the use in both accounts of bituminous substances for calking the vessel. Utnapishtim employs pitch (kupru) and asphalt (iṭṭû) to make his boat watertight, while Noah uses only pitch (kōfer) for the same purpose.

The mere reference to the use of mineral pitch in both narratives, for the purpose of rendering the boat impervious to the waters of the flood, is not particularly remarkable, for surface deposits (which alone enter into consideration) of bituminous materials occurred in various parts of the ancient world. The three most important bitumen regions known in antiquity are found in Mesopotamia and in Iran (or Persia). Beginning with the easternmost, they are the zone on both sides of the river Karûn, north of the Persian Gulf; the zone between the Tigris and the Zagros Mountains; and the zone around Ḥit and Ramadi, on the western bank of the lower Euphrates. Of these, the last-named area, where seepages and streams yield bitumen in a form virtually ready for use, was the most important center in ancient times. Also in Syria and Palestine there were rich surface deposits of bitumen, especially in and around the Dead Sea, whence bitumen was exported to Egypt, which is poor in this material. A reference to such deposits in the Dead Sea area is found in Gen. 14:10: "The valley of Siddim (consisted of) pits (upon) pits of bitumen." Unfortunately, we still know very little about the application of bitumen in ancient Palestine. About all that can be said on this point with any degree of confidence is that bitumen was used for mortar as far back as the latter part of the third millennium b.c. Whether the Palestinians in antiquity employed this material as a waterproofing medium in the construction of their ships or boats remains a problem whose solution must await further evidence.^[703]

However, what is indeed remarkable about this point of contact is the term by which this material is designated in the flood story. Elsewhere in the Old Testament, pitch, or bitumen, is expressed by ḫēmār (Gen. 11:3; 14:10; Exod. 2:3) or zefeth (Exod. 2:3; Isa. 34:9). But here, in Gen. 6:14, and nowhere else, it is called kōfer, corresponding to the Babylonian and Assyrian kupru, Arabic kufr, Aramaic kufrâ, and Armenian kupr.^[704] However, on the strength of this one word it cannot be concluded that the biblical account was derived from the Babylonian; nor can it be maintained on the basis of this passage that the term in question entered the Hebrew vocabulary with the story of the deluge.^[705] The bitumen industry presumably originated in Babylonia, the land of bitumen par excellence, where this substance served a great variety of purposes from time immemorial (as building material, a waterproofing medium, etc.), and presumably spread from there to other parts of the world, to Assyria, Arabia, Syria, Palestine, and Armenia. If this is correct, it would seem likely that the name of the substance spread with the industry or the use of the material. If bitumens were spoken of more frequently in the Old Testament than they are (only in five passages), or if we had more Hebrew literature of the Old Testament period, we might perhaps find the word kōfer in numerous passages outside the flood story and utterly unrelated to it. Had the biblical account been derived from the Babylonian and had the term under discussion not been known to the Hebrews from any other source, they would in all probability have replaced kupru by a word with which they were familiar, choosing for this purpose either ḫēmār or zefeth.^[706]

It is obvious from all this that the arguments which have been advanced in support of the contention that the biblical account rests on Babylonian material are quite indecisive.^[707]

Finally, there is a third way of accounting for the analogies between the Hebrew and the Babylonian versions of the deluge, viz., that they revert to a common source of some kind. This source need not at all have sprung from Palestinian soil but may very well have originated in the land of Babylonia, where, indeed, the Book of Genesis localizes the home of postdiluvian mankind (11:1-9) and whence Abraham emigrated to Palestine (11:27-12:5). Such a source is a very distinct possibility, especially since we know that a number of different deluge versions were current in the Tigro-Euphrates area; but for the present, at least, this explanation can be proved as little as the rest.

Concluding Remarks

As in the case of the creation stories, we still do not know how the biblical and Babylonian narratives of the deluge are related historically. The available evidence proves nothing beyond the point that there is a genetic relationship between Genesis and the Babylonian versions. The skeleton is the same in both cases, but the flesh and blood and, above all, the animating spirit are different. It is here that we meet the most far-reaching divergencies between the Hebrew and the Mesopotamian stories.

The main Babylonian flood legend, in particular, is “steeped in the silliest polytheism,” to quote the words of Dillmann.^[708] The gods are divided in their counsel, false to one another and to man; they flee in consternation to the highest heaven and cover like dogs in their distress; they quarrel and lie and gather over the sacrificer like a swarm of hungry flies! In the Babylonian accounts the moral or ethical motive is almost completely absent. As we read the first few lines of the flood story on Tablet XI of the Gilgamesh Epic, we get the impression that the cataclysm was caused by the caprice of the gods, for no ethical reason at all; however, toward the end of the story we are told, quite incidentally and by implication only, that the flood was due to the sin of mankind. Wherein the sin consisted is not indicated. According to the Atraḫasis Epic, the flood was sent because mankind with their noisy, hilarious gatherings disturbed the sleep of Enlil. Some such idea may also have been in the minds of the authors of the flood tradition in the Gilgamesh Epic. In none of the other Babylonian legends do we find any reason at all for the deluge, an omission which may, however, be due solely to the imperfect state in which they have come down to us. At any rate, in the Babylonian stories it is nowhere emphasized that the gods were actuated by moral ideals or that the flood was a divine visitation on human corruption. Rather, considering that the gods were intent on destroying the whole human race without discrimination between the just and the unjust, it is apparent that the gods were prompted more by caprice than by a sense of justice. It is true, the deluge hero was saved by a friendly deity because of his piety; but that was done clandestinely, through trickery, and against the decree of the gods in council.

In the biblical story, on the other hand, the flood is sent by the one omnipotent God, who is just in all his dealings with the children of men, who punishes the impenitent sinner, even if it means the destruction of the world, but who saves the just with his powerful hand and in his own way. In Genesis the deluge is clearly and unmistakably a moral judgment, a forceful illustration of divine justice meting out stern punishment to a "faithless and perverse generation" but delivering the righteous. What a serious view the biblical account takes of the moral depravity of the prediluvian race of men can be seen also, as remarked by Gunkel,^[709] from the fact that in it no tears are shed, as on Tablet XI:116-25 and 136-37, over those who perished in the flood; theirs was a just and deserved punishment. In the Hebrew document the ethical motive is so strong that God is portrayed even as regretting the very creation of man;^[710] while in the Babylonian, the gods, with the possible exception of Enlil, regret the destruction of man. Although God resolves not to send another flood, he is nowhere represented as regretting the diluvial catastrophe. Irrespective of whether or not the Hebrew account is to some degree dependent on Babylonian material, also this piece of biblical literature was "written for our learning" (Rom. 15:4), in order to rouse the conscience of the world and to give hope and comfort to the God-fearing.

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Footnotes (Heidel)

[618] L. W. King, Legends of Babylon and Egypt in Relation to Hebrew Tradition (London, 1918), p. 64.
[619] The manner in which the Atraḫasis Epic begins is, incidentally, a point in favor of treating Gen. 6:1-4 not as a separate fragment but as the introduction to the story of the deluge, regardless of whether the biblical account is dependent on the Babylonian or whether both have a common origin.
[620] Enûma elish, Tablet I:21 ff.
[621] Text published by Edward J. Harper in Beiträge zur Assyriologie, II (1894), 499:8-11, and by Erich Ebeling, Keilschrifttexte aus Assur religiösen Inhalts (Leipzig, 1919-23), No. 168: 39-42.
[622] However, this translation is not beyond criticism; for if this is the real meaning of the name, we should expect the form Utnapishtam (or Utanapishtam), i.e., the second element should stand in the accusative (as in Utamîsharam), instead of the genetive. On the basis of the Sumerian equivalent and the genetive ending in Babylonian and Assyrian, one would, in this particular instance, expect the element uta to be a substantive or nominal formation of some kind. Perhaps—the name means something like "the finder (or obtainer) of life" (cf. B. Meissner, Babylonien und Assyrien, II [Heidelberg, 1925], 113).
[623] King, op. cit., pp. 69-76; A. Ungnad and H. Gressmann, Das Gilgamesch-Epos (Göttingen, 1911), pp. 192-94.
[624] See Eduard König, Die Genesis (Gütersloh, 1919), pp. 333-34, and Franz Delitzsch, Neuer Commentar über die Genesis (Leipzig, 1887), pp. 151-52.

[625] H. L. Strack, Die Genesis (Munich, 1905), p. 25.
[626] Babylonian Religion and Mythology (London and New York, 1899), p. 130.
[627] A. Poebel, Historical Texts (Philadelphia, 1914), p. 58.
[628] Morris Jastrow, Jr., Hebrew and Babylonian Traditions (New York, 1914), p. 330, n. 1.
[629] The term bîtu, "house," as a name for the ark, does not occur in the Babylonian versions of the deluge, contrary to the opinion formerly held by some scholars, whose view was based on an erroneous interpretation of Tablet XI:24, which they rendered: "Construct a house, build a ship!" The corresponding passage in the Atraḫasis Epic (Fragment II) has very plainly: ú-bu-ut bi-ta bi-ni e-li-ip-pa. This can mean only: "Destroy (thy) house, build a ship."
[630] For references see A. Salonen, Die Wasserfahrzeuge in Babylonien (Helsinki, 1939), p. 48, n. 2.
[631] Once it occurs in the Gilgamesh Epic, Tablet II, col. ii, 33 (Old Babylonian version).
[632] H. V. Hilprecht, The Babylonian Expedition of the University of Pennsylvania, Series D, Vol. V, Fasc. 1 (Philadelphia, 1910), p. 5.
[633] Wilhelm Gesenius, Hebräisches und aramäisches Handwörterbuch über das Alte Testament, ed. Frants Buhl (Leipzig, 1915), pp. 675-76; Hermann Gunkel, Genesis (Göttingen, 1910), p. 142; Otto Procksch, Die Genesis (Leipzig, 1913), pp. 447-48.
[634] See König, op. cit., pp. 344-45, and Hebräisches und aramäisches Wörterbuch zum Alten Testament (Leipzig, 1931), p. 383.
[635] I take ḫallôn to denote either the same thing as the ṣōhar or a part thereof.
[636] A. Dillmann, Genesis, trans. W. B. Stevenson, I (Edinburgh, 1897), 272; Delitzsch, op. cit., p. 171; S. R. Driver, The Book of Genesis (New York and London, 1904), p. 88.
[637] H. Usener, Die Sintfluthsagen (Bonn, 1899), pp. 48-50; Sir J. G. Frazer, Folk-lore in the Old Testament, I (London, 1918), 156-57.
[638] Legends ...., pp. 80-81.
[639] Paul Haupt in Beiträge zur Assyriologie, X, Heft 2 (1927), 8.
[640] A. Schott in Zeitschrift für Assyriologie, XL (1931), 16.
[641] H. Zimmern in Eberhard Schrader, Die Keilinschriften und das Alte Testament (Berlin, 1903), p. 548, n. 5; Poebel, op. cit., p. 44, n. 3.
[642] König, Historisch-comparative Syntax der hebräischen Sprache (Leipzig, 1897), § 316, b.
[643] See Gesenius, op. cit., under שְׁנַיִם; and Dillmann, op. cit., pp. 275 and 277.
[644] Thus Dillmann, op. cit., p. 253; Delitzsch, op. cit., pp. 175-76; and Driver, op. cit., p. 90.
[645] Thus Gunkel, op. cit., p. 146; König, Die Genesis, p. 351, n. 3; John Skinner, A Critical and Exegetical Commentary on Genesis (New York, 1910), p. 168; and Procksch, op. cit., p. 449.
[646] See Pauly-Wissowa, Real-Encyclopädie der classischen Altertumswissenschaft, Vol. VIII (Stuttgart, 1901), cols. 2014-15.
[647] Poebel, op. cit., p. 54.
[648] Apollodorus The Library i. 7. 2 and iii. 8. 2.
[649] In Ps. 31(32):6, Nah. 1:8, and Dan. 9:26 (Theodotion) it is the equivalent of שֵׁטֶף or שֶׁטֶף, "outpouring," "flood," "inundation."

[650] Legends ...., p. 70, n. 2.
[651] P. Jensen in Reallexikon der Assyriologie, I (Berlin and Leipzig, 1932), 11-13; A. T. Clay, The Origin of Biblical Traditions (New Haven, 1923), pp. 152-56.
[652] With this meaning of הָיָה cf., e.g., Gen. 7:10: "And it came to pass after the seven days that the waters of the flood came upon the earth"; Jer. 3:3: "The spring rain has not come."
[653] In other passages however, both mabbûl and abûbu undoubtedly have a wider meaning (cf., e.g., Gen. 9:28 and the Gilgamesh Epic, Tablet I, col. i, 6).
[654] The Face of the Earth, trans. Hertha B. C. Sollas, I (Oxford, 1904), 17-72.
[655] Ibid., p. 31.
[656] Ibid., p. 33.
[657] F. de Montessus de Ballore, Les Tremblements de terre, géographie séismologique (Paris, 1906), pp. 209-14 and Map I (cf. also J. Milne, "Catalogue of Destructive Earthquakes," in Report of the British Association for the Advancement of Science, 1911, esp. p. 731).
[658] So in Ovid Metamorphoses i. 283-84.
[659] Suess, op. cit., pp. 38-39.
[660] In Theologische Literaturzeitung, Vol. XVI (1891), col. 247.
[661] Or mêhayyām, as in Isa. 19:5.
[662] Op. cit., pp. 38 ff.
[663] The Age of the Earth (London, 1905), p. 315.
[664] According to the Sumerian recension (col. v), "all the mighty windstorms blew together."
[665] On Tablet XI:131: "The sea grew quiet, the storm abated, the flood ceased," the word "sea" apparently refers to the sea of waters produced by the deluge, as it does in line 138 and in all probability also in line 132.
[666] Cf. H. C. Rawlinson, The Cuneiform Inscriptions of Western Asia, Vol. III (London, 1870), Pl. 12, Slab 2:30-34; also R. Campbell Thompson in Cuneiform Texts from Babylonian Tablets, etc. in the British Museum, Vol. XVII (London, 1903), Pl. 42:25: la-aḫ-mi tâmti sh[u-ut] dé-a, "laḫmu's of the sea bel[onging] to Ea."
[667] Cf. Ezek. 31:15 and Exod. 36:6.
[668] Thus Lino Murillo, El Génesis (Rome, 1914), pp. 371-72.
[669] Instead of "the seventeenth day" in 7:11, the Septuagint, perhaps due to an effort to make the deluge last exactly one year, has "the twenty-seventh day."
[670] O. Neugebauer in the Journal of Near Eastern Studies, I (1942), 396-403.
[671] One double-hour is equal to about seven miles.
[672] See E. A. Wallis Budge and L. W. King, Annals of the Kings of Assyria, I (London, 1902), 305 ff.; M. Streck in Zeitschrift für Assyriologie, XV (1900), 272 ff.; and E. A. Speiser in the Annual of the American Schools of Oriental Research, VIII (1928), esp. 18 and 31.
[673] Dillmann, op. cit., pp. 282-83; Skinner, op. cit., p. 166; and König, Die Genesis, p. 354.
[674] Dillmann, op. cit., p. 285.
[675] Delitzsch, op. cit., p. 181.
[676] xi. 14.4.

[677] The view that Noah dismissed the raven first because he wanted to get rid of the unclean and therefore obnoxious bird (Lev. 11:15) at the first opportunity (Jastrow, op. cit., p. 361) is rather fanciful. If this had been Noah's intention, we cannot help wondering why he did not at the same time send out the raven's mate.
[678] With this meaning of reah hannihoah cf., e.g., Exodus, chap. 29, and Leviticus, chap. 1.
[679] That also Utnapishtim's wife was taken there, is clear from Tablet XI:202 ff.
[680] Jensen in Zeitschrift für Assyriologie, XV, 225 ff.; Poebel, op. cit., p. 62; S. N. Kramer in the Bulletin of the American Schools of Oriental Research, No. 96 (December, 1944), pp. 18-28.
[681] W. F. Albright in the American Journal of Semitic Languages and Literatures, XXXV (1918/19), 182-83; King, Legends ...., p. 86, n. 2; Salonen, op. cit., p. 53, n. 1, where numerous references to further literature on this point are found.
[682] E. Burrows and A. Deimel in Orientalia, No. 30 (1928), pp. 3-31.
[683] Jensen, Assyrisch-babylonische Mythen und Epen (Berlin, 1900), pp. 506-7 and 576; Das Gilgamesch-Epos in der Weltliteratur, I (Strassburg, 1906), 36-37; Poebel, op. cit., pp. 62-63. A different view has been expressed by Albright in the American Journal of Semitic Languages and Literatures, XXXV, 161-95.
[684] Assyrisch-babylonische Mythen und Epen, pp. 503-4.
[685] Die Literatur der Babylonier und Assyrer (Leipzig, 1907), p. 84, n. l.
[686] The Religion of Babylonia and Assyria (New York and Cincinnati, 1908), p. 205, n.
[687] In Schrader, op. cit., p. 550, n. 2.
[688] Jensen, Assyrisch-babylonische mythen und Epen, p. 547; Ebeling, Tod und Leben nach den Vorstellungen der Babylonier (Berlin and Leipzig, 1931), p. 174, n. d.
[689] Apollodorus The Library i. 7. 2, and Ovid Metamorphoses i. 348-415.
[690] Meissner, op. cit., II, 46.
[691] The Early History of the Hebrews (London, 1897), p. 125.
[692] Op. cit., p. 107.
[693] Clay, The Origin of Biblical Traditions, pp. 75-78 and 150-59: M. G. Ionides, The Régime of the Rivers Euphrates and Tigris (London and New York, 1937), esp. pp. 24-36.
[694] Babel und Bibel (Leipzig, 1902), p. 31.
[695] In the Journal of the American Oriental Society, XLV (1925), 28.
[696] Cf. Clay's rejoinder to Barton, ibid., pp. 141-42.
[697] A Dictionary of the Bible, ed. James Hastings, II (New York, 1903), 62; G. A. Smith, The Historical Geography of the Holy Land (26th ed.; New York and London), pp. 76 ff.
[698] Clay, The Origin of Biblical Traditions, p. 157.
[699] Die Flutsagen (Braunschweig, 1891), pp. 131-32.
[700] Naturalis historia vi. 24. 83 (trans. H. Rackham in the "Loeb Classical Library").
[701] Appolonius Rhodius Argonautica ii. 317-407 and 528-610. Plutarch (ca. a.d. 46-120) Scripta moralia: de sollertia animalium 13 relates that, according to the mythologists, Deucalion dispatched a dove from the ark to ascertain the condition of the weather; the return of the dove was a sign to him that the storm continued, while her failure to come back meant fair weather.

But, attractive as this observation may appear at first reading, one can hardly base an argument on it, because the probability is that this idea, if not the Deucalionic flood story in general, emanated from Babylonian sources.

[702] Gunkel, op. cit., p. 71; S. Oettli, Der Kampf um Bibel und Babel (Leipzig, 1902), p. 20. A similar passage may perhaps be found on a tablet from Ras Shamra. C. H. Gordon, The Loves and Wars of Baal and Anat (Princeton, etc., 1943), p. 33, has rendered the lines in question as follows: "The gods eat the offerings(?), the deities drink the offerings(?)." For the original see Ch. Virolleaud, La Légende phénicienne de Danel (Paris, 1936), p. 187 and Pl. V.

[703] R. J. Forbes, Bitumen and Petroleum in Antiquity (Leiden, 1936), esp. pp. 11-30 and 53-90, and "Neues zur ältesten Geschichte des Bitumens," in Bitumen, Vol. VIII (1938), Heft 6 and 7; Salonen, op. cit., pp. 146-49; J. P. Harland in the Biblical Archaeologist, V (1942), 21-22.

[704] Zimmern, Akkadische Fremdwörter (Leipzig, 1915), p. 60.

[705] Cf. Dillmann, op. cit., p. 270; Driver, op. cit., p. 87.

[706] In passing, we may make mention also of the view that mabbûl, the Hebrew term for the flood, is derived from the Babylonian abûbu, "rainstorm," "rainflood," "flood" (Gunkel, op. cit., p. 63; Procksch, op. cit., p. 448). Suffice it to say that this idea lacks evidence and that it has gained but little acceptance.

[707] The arguments relating to the date of Genesis, the integrity of the sacred writers, and the biblical doctrine of inspiration, which are frequently adduced in certain circles to disprove the second explanation, are identical with those advanced against a dependence of the Old Testament creation material on Enûma elish and have already been treated at some length in my book The Babylonian Genesis. I shall therefore pass them up and refer the reader to that study.

[708] Op. cit., p. 262.

[709] Op. cit., p. 71.

[710] (not found)